

Intergenerational Housing Misallocation and Fertility

Short model note

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Children require space, and family-sized space is the part of the housing market that young households reach last: it sits mostly in the owner-occupied stock, behind a down payment and a payment-to-income test. This note writes down a small model of that friction and what it does to fertility. Three things come out. First, every constraint on family-sized space collapses into one cap per household, and a binding cap raises the price of a child. Second, the market can clear while the existing stock is misallocated between credit-constrained young buyers and old incumbents whom the tax code pays to stay put; both wedges are measurable. Third, at fixed prices the fertility effect of a housing policy is a product: constrained mass, times pass-through to the binding cap, times the fertility response, plus an entry term.

1 Environment

The economy is populated by overlapping generations of young and old households. A young household has type $i = (y_i, a_i, B_i)$: income, liquid wealth, and inheritance exposure. It decides whether to enter the housing market; inside, it chooses a tenure, a house size, and completed fertility. Old households are of two kinds: old incumbents, last period's young owners, who choose how much of their house to keep and then exit; and old renters, last period's young renter entrants, who rent in old age and carry no wedge. Nonentrants stay outside the market in both periods. Each period a mass $\bar{M}$ of potential young households enters the pool: the maturing children of the previous cohort plus a renewal inflow. Throughout I study a stationary equilibrium, in which the cross-section reproduces itself.

Preferences. Each child claims χ units of consumption and κ units of space, and parents consume the residuals $c_i = C_i - \chi n_i$ and $s_i = h_i - \kappa n_i$:

$$u_i^Y = \log c_i + \alpha \log(h_i - \kappa n_i) + \beta \log n_i.$$

Substituting $h_i = s_i + \kappa n_i$ into a budget at user cost q gives

$$c_i + q s_i + (\chi + \kappa q) n_i = y_i :$$

the full price of a child is its consumption requirement plus the market value of the space it occupies. A useful benchmark is equal scaling, $\chi = \kappa q / \alpha$, under which a child uses consumption and space in the same proportions as its parents. Old incumbents have $u_j^O = \log c_j^O + \gamma \log h_j^O + \mathcal{B}_j(e_j)$ over consumption, retained housing, and warm-glow bequest expenditure.

Housing. There is a fixed stock $\bar{H}$ of divisible floorspace. Renting and owning are occupancy modes with different size menus,

$$h \leq \bar{h}^R \text{ (rent)}, \quad h \leq \bar{h}^O \text{ (own)}, \quad \bar{h}^R < \bar{h}^O,$$

which encode that family-sized units exist mainly as owner-occupied homes. All floorspace trades in one market, as in Coven et al. (2025): the asset price is P , and no-arbitrage ties the rental rate to it,

$$q = \rho P, \quad \rho = r + \delta + \tau^P.$$

Given q , a higher property tax lowers P and with it the down payment on any given house.

Financing. A buyer finances at most a share ϕ of the purchase, so the down payment is $(1 - \phi)Ph$, paid from pledgeable wealth $A_i(x) = a_i + xB_i + T_i^b(x)$ with $x = 1 - \tau^b$; housing payments may not exceed ψy_i .

Capital-gains taxation. A sale during life realizes the seller's accrued gain, taxed above an exclusion. A house held until death passes with a stepped-up basis, and the gain is never taxed. For an old incumbent the difference is a levy $\ell_j \geq 0$ per unit sold while alive, zero below the exclusion.

Entry. Entering is compared with an outside value $\bar{W}^E$ under extreme-value shocks of scale κ_E , which gives a logit entry probability π_i^E .

2 Households

Conditional on entry, the owner problem is

$$W_i^O = \max_{c_i, h_i, n_i} \log c_i + \alpha \log(h_i - \kappa n_i) + \beta \log n_i$$

subject to

$$c_i + qh_i + \chi n_i = y_i, \quad (1 - \phi)Ph_i \leq A_i(x), \quad qh_i \leq \psi y_i, \quad h_i \leq \bar{h}^O.$$

The renter problem is the same without the financing constraints and with $h_i \leq \bar{h}^R$. Using $P = q/\rho$, owner housing is bounded by

$$H_i^O = \min \left\{ \bar{h}^O, \frac{A_i(x)\rho}{(1 - \phi)q}, \frac{\psi y_i}{q} \right\}, \quad H_i^R = \bar{h}^R.$$

H_i^m is the effective family-housing cap: a renter is capped by the stock, a buyer by whichever of menu, collateral, or debt service is shortest. Tenure is $W_i^Y = \max\{W_i^R, W_i^O\}$.

The old incumbent enters with housing H_j^0 and an accrued gain. Each unit faces one choice: sell now and pay the tax, or keep it until death, when the tax is forgiven. She solves

$$\max_{c_j^O, h_j^O, e_j} u_j^O \quad \text{s.t.} \quad c_j^O + e_j + qh_j^O = m_j + qH_j^0 - \ell_j(H_j^0 - h_j^O), \quad 0 \leq h_j^O \leq H_j^0.$$

Selling a unit nets $q - \ell_j$. The forgiveness at death is a subsidy to staying put; it is a transfer, not a resource saving. An old renter has no carried housing and no levy: she solves the same problem with budget $c_j^O + e_j + qh_j^O = m_j$, so at an interior choice her marginal value of space is exactly q .

3 Equilibrium

Aggregate demand adds young households, old incumbents, and old renters, and the single market clears:

$$\bar{M} \int \pi_i^E h_i dG_Y(i) + \int h_j^O dF_O(j) + \int h_j^O dF_R(j) = \bar{H}.$$

A stationary equilibrium is a user cost q (and $P = q/\rho$) such that households optimize, the market clears, fiscal accounts close with lump-sum transfers, next period's old households are this period's young entrants, owners as incumbents and renters as old renters, and births plus the renewal inflow keep the cohort at $\bar{M}$. Nothing in the clearing condition asks whether the marginal family-sized unit is held by the household that values it most; that is the next section's question.

4 Constraint gaps, read off bundles

How much a constraint binds can be read off the household's own bundle. At an interior choice, a household's marginal value of space is $\alpha c/s$. For a renter,

$$MV_i^R = \frac{\alpha c_i^R}{s_i^R} = q + \zeta_i^R,$$

so $\zeta_i^R = \alpha c_i^R/s_i^R - q \geq 0$ measures the bite of the rental menu in goods. For a young owner the same gap collects the three access constraints,

$$\zeta_i^O = \underbrace{\frac{\mu_i}{\lambda_i}(1-\phi)P + \frac{\eta_i}{\lambda_i}q}_{\zeta_i^{O,F}, \text{ financing}} + \underbrace{\frac{\theta_i}{\lambda_i}}_{\text{menu}}, \quad MV_i^O = q + \zeta_i^O,$$

and when the owner menu is slack the bundle identifies the financing part alone, $\zeta_i^{O,F} = \alpha c_i^O/s_i^O - q$. For an old incumbent at an interior retention choice,

$$MV_j^O = \frac{\gamma c_j^O}{h_j^O} = q - \ell_j :$$

she keeps marginal space she values below what the market would pay, because selling it would realize the taxable gain. Old renters carry no such wedge: their marginal value is q .

The gaps price children. Multiplying the fertility first-order condition by consumption gives, in either tenure,

$$\frac{\beta c_i^m}{n_i^m} = \chi + \kappa (q + \zeta_i^m).$$

A child's space requirement is priced at the household's own shadow value of space. Children get more expensive exactly where family-sized space is hard to reach, with market prices unchanged.

5 Efficiency

The planner faces the economy's real constraints and nothing else: the stock, the size menus, goods feasibility, and the domain conditions. It does not face household budgets, since allocations are

supported by lump-sum transfers, and it does not face the financing inequalities, which restrict market purchases rather than occupancy. Let $r_i^F \geq 0$ be the marginal real cost of implementing one more unit of owner space for a financing-constrained household: zero if the planner can reassign directly, positive if it must work through costly instruments, infinite if the constraint is a primitive nothing relaxes.

Proposition 1. *Hold the stationary cross-section, entry, and tenure assignments fixed. The planner's surplus from moving one unit of space from an old incumbent at an interior retention choice to a young owner whose financing constraints bind is*

$$(q + \zeta_i^{O,F} - r_i^F) - (q - \ell_j) = \zeta_i^{O,F} + \ell_j - r_i^F.$$

The competitive allocation solves the planner's conditional problem only if no feasible pair has positive surplus. Conversely, if all financing gaps and levies are zero, the allocation satisfies the planner's conditional first-order conditions.

The proof is one variation: move dh between the two households, hold each at its prior utility with lump-sum transfers, and the residual $(\zeta_i^{O,F} + \ell_j - r_i^F)dh$ in goods is left over, a Pareto improvement under any welfare weights. Two cautions. Real menus are not market failures: a planner facing the same stock is pinned with the renter at $\bar{h}^R$. And a positive financing gap is an inefficiency only when an instrument can reach it at real cost below the value gap.

A worked example. A two-type stationary economy puts numbers on every object. Normalize $q = 1$ and set $\rho = 0.25$, so $P = 4$. The young household has $y = 1$, $a = 0.20$, $B_i = 0$, $\alpha = 0.5$, $\beta = 0.4$, $\kappa = 0.3$, equal-scaling $\chi = 0.6$; financing is $\phi = 0.80$, $\psi = 0.30$; menus are $\bar{h}^R = 0.15$, $\bar{h}^O = 1$. The old incumbent has $m = 0.2$, $H^0 = 0.25$, $\gamma = 0.5$, no bequest motive, levy $\ell = 0.2$. The stock $\bar{H} = 5/12$ is chosen so $q = 1$ clears the market; entry is deterministic, and the renewal inflow $\bar{R} = 1 - n^*$ sustains the cohort.

The young household buys: the owner cap $H^O = \min\{1, 0.25, 0.30\} = 0.25$ is the collateral component and beats the rental menu. The cap binds (the unconstrained optimum is $h^u = 1/3$), and the fertility condition gives $n^* = 0.223$, $c = 0.616$, $s = 0.183$, so the bundle reveals $\zeta^{O,F} = \alpha c/s - q = 0.68$. The incumbent's released units net $q - \ell = 0.8$, so her wealth is 0.40 and she keeps $h^O = 1/6$, valuing retained space at 0.80; her released $1/12$ plus the passive stock $1/6$ house the young buyer. Moving one unit from her to the young household frees $\zeta^{O,F} + \ell = 0.88$ in goods; the cap derivative below is $dn/dH = 0.28$; and a down-payment grant passes through at $\rho/((1 - \phi)q) = 1.25$, so 0.01 of pledgeable wealth buys 0.0125 units of space and 0.0035 children. Figure 1 draws the two sides.

6 Fertility and policy

Fix a tenure branch and let H be the effective cap. When the cap binds, fertility solves $\beta/n = \chi/c + \alpha\kappa/s$ with $c = y - qH - \chi n$ and $s = H - \kappa n$, and

$$\frac{dn}{dH} = \frac{\frac{\alpha\kappa}{s^2} - \frac{\chi q}{c^2}}{\frac{\beta}{n^2} + \frac{\chi^2}{c^2} + \frac{\alpha\kappa^2}{s^2}},$$

which is positive for every binding cap if and only if $\chi \leq \kappa q/\alpha$: relaxing access raises fertility whenever children are at least as space-intensive as their parents' own bundle.

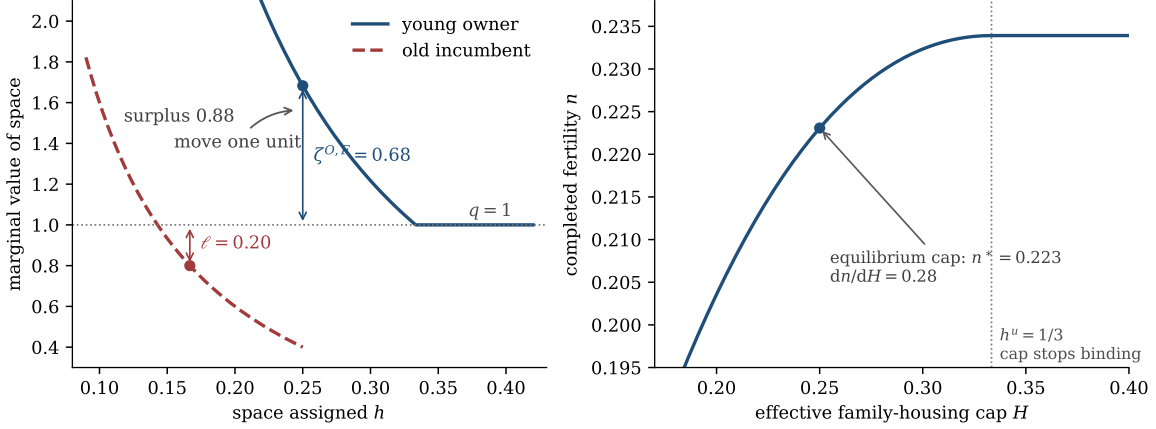


Figure 1: The worked example. Left: marginal value of space. The collateral-capped young owner sits at $h = 0.25$ valuing space at $q + \zeta^{O,F} = 1.68$; the incumbent retains $h^O = 1/6$ valuing it at $q - \ell = 0.80$; moving one unit frees 0.88 in goods. Right: completed fertility against the effective cap; at the equilibrium cap the slope is $dn/dH = 0.28$, and the cap stops binding at $h^u = 1/3$.

At fixed prices, a small policy z moves aggregate fertility through the constrained:

$$\left. \frac{dN}{dz} \right|_q = \bar{M} \sum_m \int_{\mathcal{E}_m(z)} \left[\pi_i^E \Psi_i^m + n_i^m \frac{\pi_i^E (1 - \pi_i^E)}{\kappa_E} \Theta_i^m \right] \mathcal{P}_i^m(z) dG_Y(i),$$

where $\mathcal{E}_m(z)$ is the set of households whose cap binds in branch m , $\mathcal{P}_i^m = \partial H_i^m / \partial z$ is the pass-through of the policy to the binding component of the cap, $\Psi_i^m = dn/dH$ is the fertility response, and $\Theta_i^m = \zeta_i^m / c_i^m$ drives the entry term. A policy aimed at a slack constraint moves nothing: a down-payment grant does nothing for a household pinned by the rental menu. Under equal scaling, Ψ_i^m is proportional to ζ_i^m / c_i^m , so the same gap that measures misallocation predicts whose fertility responds.

Because tenure is a discrete choice, a policy that shifts $W_i^O - W_i^R$ also moves households across the tenure boundary. In the baseline both tenures price space at the same q , an indifferent household has the same allocation in both, and the switching jump is exactly zero, so the formula above is complete. With a tenure-cost wedge the jump is signed by which tenure is the expensive way to occupy space: when owning is dearer, the marginal switcher into ownership upsizes and has more children. The long version of the note states and proves this, together with the stationary demographic closure and the full equilibrium definition.

Two notation conventions to keep in mind against the quantitative model: there M denoted the outside entry flow, while here $\bar{M}$ is the total potential-young mass and $\bar{R}$ the renewal inflow; and the per-child consumption requirement χ is common across households.

Two extensions are in progress. A quantitative lifecycle version (mortgages, income risk, an owner ladder, elastic supply) prices the same wedges in U.S. data; and the two gaps invite direct measurement, ζ from consumption-and-space bundles and ℓ from deeds, basis, and the exclusion.

References

Coven, Joshua, Sebastian Golder, Arpit Gupta, and Abdoulaye Ndiaye. 2025. “Property Taxes and Housing Allocation Under Financial Constraints.” Working paper.